



AP PHOTO

for ethnic Tamils—and one where a ballot has not been cast in the last two decades—will certainly strengthen the Government's costly but insistent argument for pushing ahead with trying to militarily defeat LTTE.

For all its jubilation, however, Rajapakse's UPFA has to face the reality that it secured 20 seats in the 37-member council only with the help of a group of former Tiger rebels, the *Thamir Makkal Viduthalai Pulikkal* (TMVP, the Tamil People's Liberation Tigers). Overshadowing the poll was LTTE defector, TMVP leader Sivanasadurai Chandrakanthan, better known as Pillayan, who helped the Government in its eastern military campaign in 2007. TMVP's armed men roaming freely in Batticaloa district have been accused of employing LTTE-like tactics, including abductions, getting rid of opponents and recruiting child soldiers.

Independent monitors charged the group with voter intimidation, rigging of ballot boxes, impersonation and other election malpractices, prompting Leader of the Opposition Ranil Wickremesinghe to dub the poll as "the death of free and fair elections." UPFA



KING SIDE: President Rajapakse (top); TMVP leader Pillayan

and TMVP have already had a successful pairing by winning local government elections in Batticaloa earlier this year. Repeated calls by local opposition parties, the international community and the United Nations to the Government to disarm TMVP have fallen on deaf ears, with Pillayan claiming the right to bear arms as defence against LTTE. "Political parties of all ethnic divides are freely campaigning in the east. We have not disrupted their election campaigns by any means," he said before the election. "Our weapons are

in sleeping mode and we will have to carry them until LTTE is militarily weakened." Noted political analyst Sanjana Hattotuwa of the Colombo-based think tank, the Centre for Policy Alternatives, says, "The very real fear is that Pillayan, irrespective of whether he is appointed chief minister or not, will wield power in the region using armed authority. This really questions the capacity and willingness of such actors to engage in democratic processes."

Apart from the increased violence and instability that the entrenchment of an armed faction could provoke, the likely appointment of Pillayan as chief minister of the eastern province could drive the wedge in further between the traditional rivals—minority Muslim and Tamil communities. Together, the two groups outnumber the majority Sinhalese in the region. Muslims, who backed UPFA, have pointed out that they bagged the largest number of seats in the council entitling them to the top job.

The overall significance of the election was underscored by LTTE. It made its presence felt in a region from which it has been supposedly evicted, with two bomb attacks on the eve and on the day of the poll, in Ampara town and in Trincomalee harbour. One reason that Rajapakse needed a victory of some sort is that, despite the military brass promising a quick end to LTTE, troops are mired in a war that is set to top \$1.5 billion this year and have met with fierce rebel resistance. LTTE has also kept up its suicide bombings on civilian targets and assassinated highways minister Jeyaraj Fernandopulle.

Although the international community, notably key supporters Japan, India, the US and the EU, consistently urge for restarting of political negotiations, the Government is determined to press on with its hard option, despite increasing operational costs and a rising body count. "Politically, the eastern elections will remain a sore point with the Indians because they will now further cement the de-merger. Indians can't be cheering about," said a Colombo analyst who didn't want to be named. Nor will LTTE take it lying down. They are expected to renew the military battle with the Government with greater ferocity. ■